

Chess Improvement Ideas

This document outlines some advice on getting better at chess that I find myself giving regularly, along with some resources that I recommend. This advice might help anyone, but it should be especially useful for players rated below 1700 USCF (maybe ~1900 online, though this depends a lot on the server and time control). A few of the resources recommended here are my own books and Lichess studies. These can be found at <https://github.com/chessisfun/chess-files> and <https://lichess.org/study/by/TeachingMaterials>

Playing

- Play regularly online or in tournaments.
- Good site to play online for adults: Lichess (<https://lichess.org/>).
- Good site to play online for kids: either ChessKid (<https://www.chesskid.com/>) or Lichess with kid mode enabled (*username* > preferences > kid mode).
- Play games against actual people, rather than exclusively playing engines/bots.
- When playing online, choose time controls with increment (e.g. “15+10” rather than “15+0”).
- Play a mixture of time controls, some faster (e.g. “10+5”) and some slower (e.g. “30+20”).
Don’t neglect slower time controls since they are especially useful for improvement.
- With any time control, try to use most of the time you are given. You should not typically finish a game with a large amount of time remaining on your clock.

Reviewing Your Games

- Use an engine to review every game you play.
- First, have the engine do a complete, automated analysis of the game.
- Next, do further analysis of your own (with the engine running to catch mistakes).
- Don’t blindly trust the engine. Instead, “argue” with the engine by playing moves that make sense to you and seeing what the engine wants to do in response.
- Use an engine and database to decide what you will play the next time you see the same opening.
- Quickly look at a couple of games of strong players that featured the same opening. Where do they put their pieces? What are some typical plans in the position?

Tactics

- Solve tactics puzzles.
- Puzzle books are generally better than online puzzles (just my opinion; people disagree on this).
- Don't spend more than 5 minutes trying to solve a puzzle (if rated below ~2000).
- Make sure you understand the solution.
- If using a book, go through the same book more than once.
- For best results, especially with easier books, keep going through the book until you can get most problems right quickly (~5 seconds per problem).
- Initially, choose books that are very easy. As you master these, gradually choose harder books.
- Make sure to include some books emphasizing checkmate patterns and some emphasizing standard tactical motifs (pins, forks, skewers, etc.).

Recommended Tactics Books:

- *Simple Checkmates* by A.J. Gilliam (ISBN: [034540307X](#))
- *Chess Tactics for Students* by John Bain (ISBN: [0963961403](#))
- *A World Champion's Guide to Chess* by Susan Polgar (ISBN: [1941270328](#))
- *Back to Basics: Tactics* by Dan Heisman (ISBN: [1888690348](#))
- *How to Beat Your Dad at Chess* by Murray Chandler (ISBN: [1901983056](#))
- *Chess Tactics for Champions* by Susan Polgar (ISBN: [9780812936711](#))
- *Manual of Chess Combinations Vol. 1b* by Sergei Ivashchenko (ISBN: [5946930443](#))
- *1001 Deadly Checkmates* by John Nunn (ISBN: [1906454256](#))
- *Winning Chess Exercises for Kids* by Jeff Coakley (ISBN: [1895525101](#))

Basic Strategy

- Read a book that gives an overview of basic strategic ideas.
- I list a few books below just to give you some options, but you don't need all of them. One or two books of this kind should be fine.
- You can study these books with a board or just read them casually.
- The important thing is just to get a big picture view of chess strategy.

Recommended Strategy Books:

- [Introduction to Chess Strategy](#) (my book)
- *Play Winning Chess* by Yasser Seirawan (ISBN: [1857443314](#))
- *The Amateur's Mind* by Jeremy Silman (ISBN: [9781890085025](#))

Complete Games

- Study complete games of stronger players.
- Initially, use books of lightly annotated games.
- You will find these books easier and more helpful once you have finished at least a couple of the recommended tactics books.
- Play through the moves of each game on a physical board or a computer program (e.g. Lichess analysis board, Chessbase, etc.)
- Spend about 15-30 minutes in total on a single game.
- Go over each game at least a couple of times.
- Read the author's comments, but question them (don't trust them).
- Find a couple of important moves that don't make sense to you.
- Analyze (by actually moving the pieces around) and try to better understand the things you find confusing.
- Either don't use an engine at all or don't turn it on until you have analyzed the game on your own for a while.
- As a bonus, see if you can memorize some of the game. Don't try to keep the game memorized in the long term, just see if you can memorize it temporarily.

Recommended Game Collections:

- *Logical Chess: Move by Move* by Irving Chernev (ISBN: [0713484640](#))
- *Simple Attacking Plans* by Fred Wilson (ISBN: [1936277441](#))
- *Chess: The Art of Logical Thinking* by Neil McDonald (ISBN: [0713488948](#))
- *50 Essential Chess Lessons* by Steve Giddins (ISBN: [1904600417](#))
- *Simple Chess* by Michael Stean (ISBN: [0486424200](#))
- *Chess Secrets: The Giants of Strategy* by Neil McDonald (ISBN: [1857445414](#))
- *Understanding Pawn Play in Chess* by Drazen Marovic (ISBN: [1911465945](#))
- *Capablanca's Best Chess Endings* by Irving Chernev (ISBN: [0486242498](#))
- *Chess Structures* by Mauricio Flores Rios (ISBN: [178483274X](#))

Endgames

- Endgames are less important than many people believe.
- Below ~2000, your goal should be to master a small number of fairly basic endgames.
- You don't need all of the books listed below, but I list a few to give you some options.

Endgame Resources:

- [Introduction to Chess Endgames](#) (my book)
- *100 Endgames You Must Know* by Jesus de la Villa (ISBN: [908331121X](#))
- *Chess Endings: Essential Knowledge* by Yuri Averbakh (ISBN: [1857440226](#))

Openings

- You should have an opening repertoire and learn the basics of the openings you play.
- However, don't spend too much time on openings. They are less important than other things.
- Keep your repertoire narrow and choose reasonably good openings.
- Stick with the same openings long enough to get fairly comfortable with them.
- Don't try to memorize large amounts of opening theory all at once. Instead, learn a little more theory every time you play a game.
- However, studying complete games that feature your preferred openings is never a bad idea, just as long as you study the entire game and not just the opening phase.
- Get a book that covers all the openings in chess at a shallow, easy level. Study this entire book in a casual way. The book by van der Sterren below is my recommendation for this.
- If you are rated at least 1200, it can be a good idea to get some books on specific openings. A few good series of books are listed in the resources section.
- If you don't have a repertoire yet and just want a decent one to start with you can use the repertoires provided among [my Lichess studies](#).
- I don't generally recommend Chessable or similar products. They put too much emphasis on memorizing things and not enough on analyzing and trying to understand things. They also encourage you to learn too much opening theory all at once.
- However, Chessable courses can provide good repertoires, the same way that repertoire books do. If you use Chessable for this purpose, I recommend that you use it for reference when reviewing your games, rather than studying from it directly.

Opening Study Resources:

- *Fundamental Chess Openings* by Paul van der Sterren (ISBN: [9781906454135](#))
- *Starting Out* series by Everyman Chess
- *Chess Explained* series by Gambit Publications
- *Move by Move* series by Everyman Chess
- [My Lichess Studies](#)